



Champions again: Petroleum men and Reserve Bank of India women (facing page), and their coaches, proudly pose with the winners' trophies and gold medals after retaining the team titles. RAKESH RAO

the polling booth armed with a printed list of office-bearers they were asked to vote for.

In such a divided house, united by a mutual hunger for power, the friction between the two sides was hard to miss throughout 2023.

Ahlawat was almost inactive, while Kamlesh, with hardly any experience in administration at this level, could do little as the season's first national ranking tournament in Hyderabad proved an unmitigated logistical disaster.

On the brighter side, things improved with each of the five national ranking tournaments, ending with the one in Panchkula, Haryana, the home turf of the TTFI president. But playing four back-to-back tournaments culminating in the all-important national championship meant too much for the majority of players.

As Kamlesh explained, "We did so at the behest of the top players who wanted the TTFI to be done with the

senior circuit by December end so that they could focus on the upcoming WTT events leading to the World Team Championship. India, as a team, has a good chance to qualify in the men's section of the Paris Olympic Games. We understand the schedule for the rest of the players was tight, but we couldn't help it."

A day after the culmination of the last national ranking event, the national championship began at the same venue and proved to be a huge success. Haryana, known for its generous hospitality, once again left no stone unturned and organised the best event of the year.

Add to it a full field in the men's and women's singles, and the effort seemed all worth it. Though fancied names like Sharath Kamal and Manika Batra made premature exits, there was no dearth of thrilling action. In the end, Harmeet Desai claimed his second national singles title, while little-known Poymantee Baisya became the new women's singles winner.

Much like the All India Chess Federation (AICF), the TTFI, too, decided to allow the highly questionable 'pay-and-play' offer. This meant a player could pay Rs. 6,000 and play singles alongside the selected players from his or her state

or institutions and get a Certificate of Participation, whatever it's worth, from the TTFI.

This was done to attract more revenue for the host state and the TTFI, their share being 60:40. No wonder; a record number of entries were seen. While the TTFI, the host, and the players were happy, the hapless technical officials, umpires, etc. had to officiate from 8 a.m. to around midnight for the initial days.

With the main draws in singles getting over in just two days, G. Sathiyam pointed to the fact that the finalists could play as many as seven matches in two days. The scheduling of the quarterfinals, semifinals, and finals on the same day was not appreciated by the players.

Coming to the on-table action, there were some predictable outcomes, like the Petroleum men and the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) women retaining the team titles. It was the 27th occasion for Petroleum and a second in succession for RBI. When you employ the most-performing names in Indian table tennis, such results are not difficult to guess.

With Petroleum women failing to qualify, the journey proved comfortable for RBI, relying on defending singles winner Sreeja